

Mating

When mating, the male grasps the female's head using claspers at the end of his abdomen (the long tail-like part). She curls her abdomen underneath him so that he can fertilize her eggs.

Dragonflies may mate on a perch, or even in midair while still flying.

Laying eggs

The female green darner inserts her eggs into tiny slits that she makes in the stems of water plants. Often the male will hold her while she is laying eggs.

Hatching

The larva that hatches from the egg is called a nymph. Breathing through gills in its rectum (bottom), a dragonfly nymph lives underwater for months or even years, depending on the species.

The nymph is a fierce hunter of small fish, tadpoles, and insect larvae.

Prehistoric ancestors Fossils show that dragonflies evolved around 300 million years ago. Some ancient dragonflies were scarily big, with wingspans of up to 2 ft (60 cm).



Mosquito Like dragonflies, mosquitoes live underwater when they're larvae. Unlike dragonflies, however, they go through complete metamorphosis—the larvae turn into floating pupae before becoming winged adults.



Mayfly Mayflies have a larval stage in water, too. Once out in the air, they often live for no more than a day as adults. The adults don't feed—they spend their brief time mating, and then they die.

